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Baca earns 'Bravo' from Miner bosses

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Sergio Baca would like to be known as Charlie Hustle. His teammates think of him as the silent wonder. Actually, he's an undersized second baseman with an oversized bat.

Baca spent most his freshman season at UTEP watching All-WAC second baseman Art Bravo complete his eligibility. Riding the bench was something new to the former Burges High School star who earned all-city honors his junior and senior years. Baca was used to being on the field, not in the dugout.

But, like everything else he does, Baca made the most of the situation by studying Bravo's technique and learning what major college baseball is all about. When Baca's turn came to show his stuff, it was as if Bravo had never graduated.

"I always knew Sergio could field and he's always been able to hit but I didn't think he would come around this early," said Miner Coach Larry McFarlin. "He's done everything we could ask out of a ballplayer."

Miner assistant Dan McMahon, a shortstop in his playing days, echoes McFarlin's comments. "Sergio wants to learn and he never backtalks when you're trying to teach him something. He just listens to you and goes out and does it. He's the best student of the game I've ever seen."

"Sergio has always been quiet," added McFarlin. "He's willing to be corrected and that makes him a good player. There are a lot of players around who want to do their own thing. Sergio works hard and doesn't let things bother him."

Former UTEP coach Andy Cohen rates Baca among the best infielders

ever to wear a Miner uniform.

Indeed, Baca has come through like a veteran. With the 1980 season almost at the midway point, Baca leads UTEP's hitters with a .437 batting average. The 140-pounder has yet to show any tendencies toward letting up on his torrid pace.

Baca knows his limits, which do not include going for the long ball.

"I'm a singles hitter, that's all," admits Baca. "I've never hit a homer in my life and I don't ever expect to. People who go for the long ball tend to strikeout and that's something I try not to do. All I want to do is get on base and score a lot of runs. That's what I like to do."

Scoring runs has been one of Baca's specialties. Batting behind Danny Haygood in the No. 2 spot, Baca has 36 singles and six doubles in 96 times at bat. With power-hitters James Walker (.432), Mike Brooks (.313) and Tommy Thompson (.397) following suit, Baca has already crossed home plate 40 times.

"It's always been a goal of mine to bat .400. As long as you can go 2-for-5, get a couple of hits a game, it's possible," said Baca, who admits he has a bigger goal in mind, one which centers not around himself but the UTEP baseball program.

"I wish we could have a good program at UTEP. It would be nice if we could be like Arizona. I'm from El Paso and I'd like to make something out of the baseball program here before I leave."

Baca had his opportunities to go elsewhere. Both Brigham Young University and the University of Houston looked at him seriously, but being a home-grown product, Baca wanted to stay in El Paso and improve the local baseball scene.

Whether that is possible is up to the university, not Baca. At the end of this season, UTEP's campus field will become part of a new business college and, with no plans announced to replace the field, it's difficult for anybody to be too optimistic about the future of UTEP baseball.



Sergio Baca